Portia

If I could bid the fifth welcome with so good heart as I can bid the other four farewell, I should be glad of his approach: if he have the condition of a saint and the complexion of a devil, I had rather he should shrive me than wive me.

Come, Nerissa. — *Sirrah,* go before.—

Whiles we shut the gate upon one wooer, another knocks at the door. *[Exeunt*

145. *approach:* arrival.
146. *condition:* nature.
complexion: appearance.
147. *I had:* I should prefer.
shrive me: hear my sins and grant forgiveness like a holy man.
148. *wive:* marry.
149. *Sirrah:* expression addressing a servant.

Act I : Scene 3

In this scene, Shylock, the Jewish moneylender, is introduced. He is the most powerful dramatic figure in the play. Shylock's hatred for Antonio intensifies the drama. Having been ridiculed by Antonio for years, he does not want to lend money to his friend Bassanio. But foreseeing an opportunity to take his revenge on Antonio, he agrees to give the loan on a bond which would allow Shylock to cut off a pound of Antonio's flesh, if he fails to repay the loan in time. The bond story is the main plot around which all action in the play takes place.

Scene 3 *Venice. A public place*
Enter Bassanio *and* Shylock

Shylock

Three thousand ducats, — well.

Bassanio

Ay, sir, for three months.

Shylock

For three months, — well.

Bassanio

For the which, as I told you, Antonio shall be bound.

Shylock

Antonio shall become bound, — well.

1. *ducats:* Venetian gold coins.
2. *Ay:* yes.
4. *For the which:* for which.
4-5. *be bound:* act as surety, as guarantor.
6. *well:* understand.

Bassanio

May you stead me? will you pleasure me?
shall I know your answer?

Shylock

Three thousand ducats, for three months,
10 and Antonio bound.

Bassanio

Your answer to that,

Shylock

Antonio is a good man.

Bassanio

Have you heard any imputation to the contrary?

Shylock

15 Ho, no, no, no, no; my meaning in saying he is a good man is to have you understand me that he is sufficient. Yet his means are in supposition: he hath an argosy bound to Tripolis, another to the Indies; I understand,
20 moreover, upon the Rialto, he hath a third at Mexico, a fourth for England, — and other ventures he hath, squandered abroad. But ships are but boards, sailors but men: there be land-rats and water-rats, water-
25 thieves and land-thieves — I mean pirates; and then there is the peril of waters, winds, and rocks. The man is, notwithstanding, sufficient. Three thousand ducats; I think I may take his bond.

Bassanio

30 Be assured you may.

Shylock

I will be assured I may; and, that I may be assured,
I will bethink me. May I speak with Antonio?

7. *May you stead me?:* Will you help me?

   pleasure: oblige.

12. *good:* wealthy; Bassanio takes the word in its ordinary sense and Shylock explains the sort of goodness he means.

13. *imputation:* allegation.

13-4. *to the contrary?:* that he is not.

17. *sufficient:* financially adequate as surety for the 3000 ducats.

17-8. *in supposition:* subject to the risks of business.

18. *argosy:* merchant ship.

19. *Tripolis:* Tripoli on the Mediterranean coast of Africa; it was a great channel of trade to central Africa — a vivid impression of the world-wide trade of Venice (and England).

20. *the Rialto:* the Venetian Stock Exchange where the merchants met for the transaction of business.

22. *ventures:* business investments.

    squandered abroad: uselessly scattered abroad; implying perhaps that Antonio has not acted prudently in risking so much all at once. He then outlines the dangers for Antonio's goods.

23. *boards:* planks of wood.

    men: mortal men.

27-8. *The man...sufficient:* nevertheless the man is acceptable (satisfactory) as security.

31. *I will ....I may:* I would like to be assured that I may.

32. *bethink me:* think it over.

    with: to.

Bassanio

If it please you to dine with us.

Shylock

Yes, to smell pork; to eat of the habitation
35 which your prophet the Nazarite conjured
the devil into. I will buy with you, sell with
you, talk with you, walk with you, and so
following; but I will not eat with you, drink
with you, nor pray with you. What news on
40 the Rialto?—Who is he comes here?

Enter Antonio

Bassanio

This is Signior Antonio.

Shylock

[Aside] How like a fawning publican he
looks!
I hate him for he is a Christian;
But more, for that in low simplicity
45 He lends out money gratis and brings down
The rate of usance here with us in Venice.
If I can catch him once upon the hip,
I will feed fat the ancient grudge I bear him.
He hates our sacred nation; and he rails,
50 Even there where merchants most do
congregate,
On me, my bargains, and my well-won thrift,

---

50. *there where:* on the Rialto.

congregate: gather.

51. *bargains:* business deals.

well-won: hard-earned.

thrift: success, gain.

34. *Yes:* ironical expression meaning "what?" *pork:* meat forbidden to the Jews, *habitation:* pig's body (dwelling place of the devil according to Shylock).

34-6. *the habitation...into:* Jesus Christ ('*The Nazarite*') healed a madman by ordering the devils that possessed him to leave the man and enter into a herd of pigs (St. Marks 5:1-13).

35. *Nazarite:* a resident of Nazareth.

conjured: ordered.

36-7. *I will buy...talk with you:* I am ready to buy and sell with you.

37-8. *so following:* so forth.

40. Who is he *that* comes here?

42. *fawning:* servile.

publican: Roman tax-collector. (Reference is made to the parable of the publican and the Pharisee, Luke XVIII, 10-14.) *Publican* is a natural term of contempt and loathing in the mouth of a Jew.

43. *for:* because.

44. *low*: base.

simplicity: foolishness.

45. *gratis:* free of interest.

46. *usance:* interest or money lending.

47. *catch him...hip:* get hold of him at a disadvantage. (The metaphor is from wrestling, referring to a position leading to a throw.)

48. *feed fat:* fully gratify (as though the grudge were an animal to be fed).

ancient grudge: long-standing grievance.

49. *sacred nation:* Jewish race.

rails: abuses.

Which he calls interest. Cursed be my tribe,
If I forgive him!

Bassanio

Shylock, do you hear?

Shylock

55 I am debating of my present store;
And, by the near guess of my memory,
I cannot instantly raise up the gross
Of full three thousand ducats. What of that?
Tubal, a wealthy Hebrew of my tribe,
60 Will furnish me. But soft! how many months
Do you desire? [*To Antonio*] Rest you fair, good signior;
Your worship was the last man in our mouths.

Antonio

Shylock, albeit, I neither lend nor borrow
By taking nor by giving of excess,
65 Yet, to supply the ripe wants of my friend,
I'll break a custom.—[*To* Bassanio] Is he yet possessed
How much ye would?

Shylock. Ay,ay, three thousand ducats.

Antonio

And for three months.

Shylock

70 I had forgot; three months; you told me so.
Well then, your bond; and let me see; but hear you;
Methought you said you neither lend nor borrow
Upon advantage.

52. *interest:* profit.
tribe: race.
55. *debating of:* calculating.
present store: ready money.
56. *near:* close.
57. *gross:* the full sum.
58. *What...that?:* That does not matter.
59. *a wealthy...tribe:* a wealthy Jew of my community.
tribe: the Jews were divided into 12 tribes or family groups.
60. *furnish:* supply.
But soft!: wait a little.
61. *Rest you fair:* a greeting.
62. *Your worship:* your honour, a title of respect.
in our mouths: that we were talking about.
63. *albeit:* although.
64. *excess:* interest, more money than the sum borrowed or lent.
65. *ripe:* immediate, pressing.
wants: needs.
66-7. *Is he...possessed:* Is he aware yet of the amount you want?
67. *would:* want.
72. *Methought:* It seems to me, I think.
73. *Upon advantage:* with interest.

Antonio

I do never use it.

Shylock

75 When Jacob grazed his uncle Laban's sheep,—

This Jacob from our holy Abraham was,

(As his wise mother wrought in his behalf)

The third possessor: ay, he was the third,—

Antonio

And what of him? did he take interest?

Shylock

80 No, not take interest; not, as you would say,

Directly interest; mark what Jacob did.

When Laban and himself were compromised

That all the eanlings which were streak'd and pied

Should fall as Jacob's hire.

85 This was a way to thrive, and he was blest:

And thrift is blessing, if men steal it not.

Antonio

This was a venture, sir, that Jacob served for;

A thing not in his power to bring to pass,

But sway'd and fashion'd by the hand of heaven.

90 Was this inserted to make interest good?

Or is your gold and silver ewes and rams?

89-90. It was controlled and shaped by the hand of God. Was this mentioned in order to justify charging of interest?

91. *ewes and rams?:* ... that multiply.

74. *I do...it:* I have never done it.

75. *grazed:* led out to pasture.

76. Abraham was the founder of the Jewish race. Isaac was his son and Jacob was the grandson of Abraham.

77. *wrought:* schemed.

78. *The third possessor:* Jacob was third in the line of heirs to family estates. The first one being Abraham and the second, Isaac. Jacob should not have been the heir, since he was younger than his brother Esau. But Jacob's mother played a trick to have Jacob made Isaac's heir.

82. *compromised:* agreed.

83. *eanlings:* new-born lambs.

streak'd and pied: were with fleeces of two colours.

81-4. **Note:** A reference is made to the following story in the Bible. Jacob, son of Isaac, went to serve under his uncle Laban. An agreement was made between Jacob and Laban that the former should receive for his services the lambs which were born with spots or stripes. During the breeding season Jacob placed wooden rods in such a position that the shadows of the rods could fall on the sheep. By this means Jacob is said to have influenced the sheep so much that almost all the lambs were born spotted or striped, and thus they became the property of Jacob.

84. *fall...hire:* be counted as Jacob's wages.

85. *thrive:* succeed.

86. *thrift:* profit.

87. *This...for:* This was an enterprise for which Jacob worked (as a servant).

88. *A thing...pass:* it was a thing which his power could not cause to happen.

Shylock

I cannot tell; I make it breed as fast:
But note me, signior.

Antonio

Mark you this, Bassanio,
95 The devil can cite Scripture for his purpose.
An evil soul, producing holy witness,
Is like a villain with a smiling cheek;
A goodly apple rotten at the heart:
O what a goodly outside falsehood hath!

Shylock

100 Three thousand ducats; 'tis a good round sum.
Three months from twelve: then, let me see, the rate—

Antonio

Well, Shylock, shall we be beholding to you?

Shylock

Signior Antonio, many a time and oft
In the Rialto you have rated me
105 About my moneys and my usances:
Still have I borne it with a patient shrug,
For sufferance is the badge of all our tribe;
You call me misbeliever, cut-throat dog,
And spit upon my Jewish gaberdine,
110 And for all use of that which is mine own.
Well then, it now appears you need my help:
Go to then; you come to me, and you say,
"Shylock, we would have moneys": you say so;
You, that did void your rheum upon my beard,
115 And foot me as you spurn a stranger cur
Over your threshold; moneys is your suit.

95. *cite:* quote.
for his purpose: to justify his purpose.

96. *holy witness:* holy arguments; scripture.

98. *goodly:* attractive.
heart: inside.

99. *outside:* appearance.

100. *round:* substantial.

102. *beholding:* indebted (i.e. Are you going to lend us money?)

103. *oft* : often.

104. *rated:* abuse; scolded.

105. *usances:* moneylending deals.

106. *Still:* always.

107. *sufferance:* long suffering.
badge: characteristic.
tribe: race.

108. *misbeliever:* non-believer.
cut-throat: murderous; merciless.

109. *gaberdine:* a long loose cloak worn traditionally by Jews.

110. *And...own:* And all this because I put to use that which is my own.

112. *Go to:* Come.

114. *void your rheum:* spit.

115. *foot:* kicked.
stranger cur: stray dog.

116. *Over your threshold:* out of your house.
suit: request.

What should I say to you? Should I not say,
"Hath a dog money? is it possible
A cur can lend three thousand ducats?" or
120 Shall I bend low, and in a bondman's key,
With bated breath and whispering humbleness,
Say this,—
"Fair sir, you spit on me on Wednesday last;
You spurn'd me such a day; another time
125 You call'd me dog; and for these courtesies
I'll lend you thus much moneys"?

Antonio

I am as like to call thee so again,
To spit on thee again, to spurn thee too.
If thou wilt lend this money, lend it not
130 As to thy friends—for when did friendship take
A breed for barren metal of his friend?—
But lend it rather to thine enemy;
Who, if he break, thou mayest with better face
Exact the penalty.

Shylock

135 Why, look you, how you storm!
I would be friends with you and have your love,
Forget the shames that you have stain'd me with,
Supply your present wants, and take no doit
Of usance for my moneys, and you'll not hear me:
140 This is kind I offer.

Bassanio

This were kindness.

---

141. *This were kindness:* That would indeed be kindness on your part.

120. *bondman's key:* a voice like a slave.

121. *With bated breath:* anxiously.

whispering humbleness: humble whisper.

123. *Fair:* noble.

124. *spurn'd:* pushed me out.

125. *courtesies:* polite actions.

127. *as like:* just as likely.

131. *A breed...metal:* a product of sterile metal, that is, interest.

130-1. *for when did...of his friend?:* The classic example of anti-usury, i.e., when did any friend take from his friend a profit on a loan of unproductive money?

133-4. *Who, if...penalty:* From whom, if he defaults, *you* can, without guilt, take your penalty.

135. *Why...storm!:* See, how *you* have become angry !

137. *shames:* insult.

stain'd: disgraced.

138. *Supply...wants:* supply what *you* need now.

doit: a small insignificant sum (A doit was a small Dutch coin).

139. *usance:* interest.

140. *This is...offer:* (i) It is kindness that I offer.

(ii) Kind is used as in the sentence: A *man likes* the *company of his own kind.* Thus Shylock means, "This is your system of loan which I offer, without any interest."

(iii) Kind also has the usage: to pay a man in kind which means to return similar treatment to him. So Shylock may have thought here that he intends to repay Antonio with insults similar to those he had received himself.

Shylock This kindness will I show;
Go with me to a notary, seal me there
Your single bond; and, in a merry sport,
145 If you repay me not on such a day,
In such a place, such sum or sums as are
Express'd in the condition, let the forfeit
Be nominated for an equal pound
Of your fair flesh, to be cut off and taken
150 In what part of your body pleaseth me.

Antonio
Content, i'faith: I'll seal to such a bond,
And say there is much kindness in the Jew.

Bassanio
You shall not seal to such a bond for me:
I'll rather dwell in my necessity.

Antonio
155 Why, fear not, man; I will not forfeit it:
Within these two months, that's a month before
This bond expires, I do expect return
Of thrice three times the value of this bond.

Shylock
O father Abram, what these Christians are,
160 Whose own hard dealings teaches them suspect
The thoughts of others! Pray you, tell me this;
If he should break his day, what should I gain
By the exaction of the forfeiture?
A pound of man's flesh, taken from a man
165 Is not so estimable, profitable neither,
As flesh of muttons, beefs, or goats. I say,
To buy his favour, I extend this friendship:
If he will take it, so; if not, adieu;

142. *This kindness...show:* perhaps here it means, "I shall return similar treatment."

143. *notary:* a solicitor; a legal officer.

seal me: sign for me.

144. *single:* a bond undertaken by one man, i.e., it was signed by Antonio alone.

merry sport: for a pleasant joke.

147. *condition:* terms of the contract.

forfeit: penalty.

148. *Be nominated:* named as, assessed at.

equal: exactly a pound (from the scales being equally balanced when the one pound weight is in the one and the flesh in the other.) Note the irony Shylock himself emphasises the condition 'an exact pound.'

151. *Content, i'faith:* I am indeed content.

153. *seal:* sign, finalise.

154. *I'll rather...necessity:* I would rather remain in my present state of need.

158. *Of thrice three times:* nine times, many times.

160. *hard:* tough.

suspect: be suspicious of.

162. *break his day:* break his promise to pay on a certain day.

163. *exaction:* taking.

165. *estimable:* valuable.

167. *buy:* gain.

168. *take:* accept.

so: all right.

adieu: goodbye.

And, for my love, I pray you wrong me not.

Antonio

170 Yes, Shylock, I will seal unto this bond.

Shylock

Then meet me forthwith at the notary's;
Give him direction for this merry bond;
And I will go and purse the ducats straight;
See to my house, left in the fearful guard
175 Of an unthrifty knave, and presently
I'll be with you.

Antonio

Hie thee, gentle Jew. [*Exit* Shylock
The Hebrew will turn Christian: he grows kind.

Bassanio

I like not fair terms and a villain's mind.

Antonio

180 Come on: in this there can be no dismay;
My ships come home a month before the day.
[*Exeunt*

169. *And...me not:* But do not be unjust to me for offering this act of love.
171. *notary's:* notary's office.
172. *direction for:* instructions about.
merry: humorous.
173. *purse the ducats straight:* at once make ready the ducats in a purse.
straight: at once.
174. *See...house:* ensure that my house is safe.
fearful guard: left in the unsafe care.
175. *unthrifty knave:* irresponsible servant.
presently: soon.
177. *Hie thee:* make haste.
178. *Hebrew:* The Jew (Shylock).
179. *fair terms...mind:* apparently kind words offered by a villain's mind.
180. *dismay:* reason for fear.